ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Who Does God Watch Over?

Derech Hashem, Maamar HaIkarim

Sefer: Maamar HaIkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar HaIkarim, essay 6: hashgahah, Divine providence
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These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

God oversees and sustains everything

After the essays on the spiritual world, the purpose of life, gemul and Gan Eden and Gehinnom, the sixth essay turns to hashgahah, providence. God constantly oversees and sustains all of creation, and nothing exists without His continual maintenance.

But because human beings alone are able to receive reward and punishment, God's dealings with them are different. With every other species He oversees the species as a whole, not the individual creatures, since the individuals have no purpose beyond the species. Human beings He oversees individually, judging each person and giving each the consequences of his own actions.

A million giraffes

The Rabbi gave the example he had used when the group studied this in Part 2. Suppose that, for whatever reason God created giraffes, the world needs a million of them. If circumstances change and only 900,000 are needed, 100,000 will die. Which ones? "Absolutely random." There is hashgahah that there should be 900,000 giraffes, but none on which particular giraffe survives. He compared it to a business owner with a hundred identical black cabs who now needs only fifty. He will not agonise over which fifty to sell.

Nations and individuals

A participant asked about the Gemara in Sotah that God lets a nation's sins build up until the measure is full and then destroys it. Does that not treat nations like a species? The Rabbi answered that even then each person is judged individually. Being part of a corrupt society carries its own responsibility: either you should have changed it or left it. Besides, "entire nations blotted out" usually means the majority, not every last person, just as not every single Egyptian drowned. The clearest proof that non-Jews are judged individually is that a non-Jew can have a portion in Olam HaBa. "Animals are animals."

Hashgahah is a relationship

The Rabbi added a point from earlier in the book. Individual hashgahah applies to a person who wants it. Someone who chooses to live without God can live like an animal, under chance: he may die in an earthquake, or he may prosper. People who rely on charms and mazal are showing that they believe in luck, and so they place themselves under it.

He compared it to the mashgiah in a yeshiva, who watches over the boys. If a boy has no interest in being there or in any relationship, the mashgiah will lose interest in him. One of his own teachers once told him that the very fact he was punishing a student showed there was still a relationship. Asked whether being "naughty" removes hashgahah, the Rabbi said no: "It's not about naughty, it's about relationship." A person can be quite bad and still want a relationship with God. It is the one who has no interest at all who falls under mazal. The same is true of non-Jews; a godly non-Jew can have hashgahah in his life. Animals connected to people, such as a man's flock, also come under hashgahah, because their loss affects their owner.

Neutral actions

The Ramhal then divides human actions into two kinds: good or bad acts, misvot and sins, and acts that are neither. The Rabbi noted that Rabbenu Bahya ibn Pakuda, in the eleventh century, held there is no such thing as a neutral act. Everything can be traced back to a misvah or a sin. Sleep in order to have strength to work, feed your family and learn Torah, and it is good; sleep in order to commit a crime the next day, and it is bad.

"That's a very tense way to live life," the Rabbi said, though it is one legitimate way of seeing things. The Ramhal rejects it. If a person who learns Torah takes half an hour to relax in the garden, Rabbenu Bahya would say it depends on his intention, but for the Ramhal it can simply be neutral. A participant suggested such acts are in the middle and could be tipped either way by a little thought. The Rabbi agreed, and said we should think more often about why we go to work or why we are eating. Eating when not hungry may even harm the body.

The Ramhal then says that whatever touches on misvot and sins is entirely in a person's own hands; no one else can influence it, and God judges it. Other things that happen to a person, such as whether it rains on him during a walk, can be random.

Can another person break a decree?

A participant asked: surely nothing is random, and if someone is killed on the way to visit a friend, that is hashgahah? The Rabbi answered in two parts. First, it depends whether the person lives with hashgahah. Second, even then, human free will can usually override a decree.

Suppose it was decreed on Rosh Hashanah that A will live the whole year, and B decides to kill him. If B could not, or if A was "meant" to die anyway, then why is B punished? "You are destroying human free will." The same in the good direction: if it was decreed that a man would be homeless, and I take him in, wash him, clothe and feed him, have I broken God's plan? The Rabbi said he once gave a whole shiur on the many sources showing that human free will generally overrides the decree, except for a saddik or a king, where God may

intervene. A person decreed to live will not die in an earthquake or a storm, because nature cannot override the decree, but another human being can. "That's why we talk about tikkun olam": we have the ability to make the world better.

A last participant argued that if something happens, God is allowing it, so it is hashgahah. The Rabbi disagreed. When a lion devours a sheep, God gives the lion the ability, but He did not decide that this sheep should die. That is the giraffe principle again. The discussion was left "to be continued".

Summary

- God sustains everything, but watches over animals as species and over human beings as individuals.
- Which individual animal lives or dies is random; how many of the species exist is providence.
- Personal hashgahah depends on a relationship with God, not on being perfect; one who wants no relationship falls under mazal.
- The Ramhal, unlike Rabbenu Bahya, holds that some actions are neutral.
- Human free will can usually override a decree, for bad and for good, which is why we can make the world better.

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